

DESCRIPTION: This resolution seeks Town Meeting support to delay the filing to Massachusetts School Building Authority (MSBA) for the Lexington High School construction project from its current schedule.

The proponents cite a concern regarding the number of students that may result from recently planned new housing in Lexington. We share that concern, but we feel the current approach of designing to 85% occupancy (vs the existing overcrowded 95-100% utilization) plus the proposed Central Office space which can be transformed into space for an additional 244 students if/when needed for increasing enrollment is a more cost-effective method of addressing that concern. Further, the current massing studies allow for future new construction to create additional space for up to 256 students. Therefore, the current School Building Committee (SBC) plan is to have a move-in capacity for 2,395 students, with the possibility of 244 more in the planned Central Office (CO) space, plus the possibility of additions onto the proposed building which would accommodate yet another 256 students, adjustments to utilization and students per classroom could yield another 343 students (25 students per classroom at 90% utilization), and hence total potential for 3,238 students. Lastly, the current project proposal by the SBC has the additional benefit of freeing up land at the old Harrington Elementary School site for needed athletic fields and will reduce the ongoing operational costs of running the Central Office. We remind the Town Meeting that keeping the F-grade Old Harrington plant operational will require some \$20 million in Capital costs.

The proponents also claim their approach will save on construction costs. Their proposal was not one that was studied in the same level of detail as the SBC approved option. However, Dore+Whittier (the Owner's Project Manager), SMMA (the selected designer), and the Director of DPF have examined the proponents' proposed two-phase approach. The first proposed phase is to construct a 172,000 square foot (sq. ft.) building followed by a "2 to 5" year pause while the Town examines school enrollment, and finally a second phase to renovate the remaining 200,000 sq. ft., also supposedly at least partially funded by MSBA, where we would need to build an additional 88,000 sq. ft. (to match the currently agreed upon building of 460,000 sq. ft. to meet the then-enrollment numbers. This plan has several serious flaws. First, a more realistic construction cost for a 172,000 sq. ft. building, based on our own retained estimators' square footage figures, is \$243 million. Second, the SBC's own retained experts believe it would be impossible to build a 172,000 sq. ft. building in one year with Massachusetts public construction bidding law requirements and material delivery schedules. Remember, these are experts who live, breath, and sleep MSBA-funded school construction for a living and have a deep understanding of school construction costs and timelines. Third, the proponents' \$200 million figure does not consider:

1. The value of the proposed new building exceeds 30% of the current assessed value of the HS which would trigger required accessibility and structural code upgrades to the existing building that will cost approximately \$100 million,
2. The construction inflation associated with a multi-year delay for the remaining portion of the project,
3. The ongoing substandard program in the remaining existing LHS space that would stay substandard for during that multi-year pause between phases,
4. The ongoing high-operating cost of the current physical plant which would remain online during that pause,
5. The need for modular classroom swing space which is estimated to be 40 classrooms at \$400,000 per modular, or \$16 million additional unaccounted for dollars,
6. The necessarily higher 4-season operating costs for the Heating, Ventilation, and Air Conditioning (HVAC) in those lower-insulation modulars,
7. The need to pass another debt exclusion for the second phase some 2-5 years down the road,
8. The need to spend \$7 million to keep the current Field House operational while we kick the can down the road, and the need to include the Field House in the 2nd phase Debt Exclusion at inflated prices,
9. The necessary capital to maintain the current and remaining physical plant during the gap between phases which is at least a few millions of dollars, and significantly more if there are catastrophic failures to the systems which are already well past the end of their normal life,
10. Inherent design issues of the renovation portion, like (a) too low floor-to-floor elevations (also known as "Deck Heights") to allow for modern mechanical system installation; (b) inefficient classroom configurations due to existing structural bay dimensions; (c) failure to address and correct any overcrowding issues with common spaces like the cafeteria and gym, and (d) awkward connectivity between new construction and old construction requiring ramps to match floor heights and channeling students through old, narrower paths at the ground level to get from upper levels of disconnected new structures,
11. The construction costs to build the additional 88,000 sq. ft. needed to achieve the required square footage, and
12. The loss of any MSBA monies which would result from that solution.